capabilities. Areas that were once effectively ‘both men’s land’—in that they had featured patrols by both Indian and Chinese forces—had now seen patrolling patterns disrupted. Instead, Chinese and Indian moves and countermoves led to close-up and sometimes overlapping deployments.

The reasons for China’s actions along the LAC in Ladakh can only be speculated upon and may perhaps come to light in future years. The scale of deployment required the approval of China’s Central Military Commission (CMC), chaired by paramount leader Xi Jinping. It is known that the PLA had conducted war games and exercises involving Ladakh since at least 2006. [37] In 2019, the PLA inducted new equipment designed for mountain warfare among units in its Western Command. Forestalling Indian infrastructure in the Shyok River Valley that would improve supply lines to India’s northern-most military facility at Daulat Beg Oldi may have been another motive. There may also have been political reasons, with Xi believing that he would not get major concessions from India after the Wuhan and Mamallapuram summits. Finally, China’s decision may have been opportunistic: it had already recovered from a first wave of the Covid-19 pandemic, while India—including the Indian Army—remained constrained by lockdowns and pandemic protocols.

Regardless of China’s reasoning, its mobilization along the LAC had immediate effects on relations. India initiated a counter-deployment and engaged in negotiations. In June, the Indian belief that China was not following through on its commitment of disengagement in the Galwan Valley resulted in violence in which twenty Indian soldiers and several Chinese soldiers died. (China does not release information about combat deaths, but posthumously honoured four soldiers.) [38] The first violent deaths on the LAC in almost a half century proved a shocking development. India immediately retaliated with economic steps, banning certain Chinese technology, imposing greater scrutiny upon public procurement and Chinese investment, and eventually excluding Chinese companies from 5G telecommunication contracts. [39]

In late August 2020, the Indian Army conducted a military operation to seize heights on the southern bank of Pangong Tso. Conducted in stealth,